



Rough and Smooth

The two ashlar

SYMBOLISM

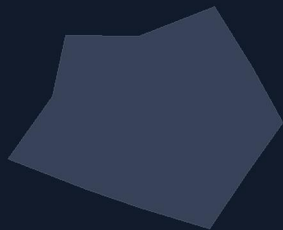
The simplest symbol in the lodge, and the one most worth ten unhurried minutes. Operative origin, speculative meaning, and why the perfect ashlar hangs rather than sits.

ON THE TABLE

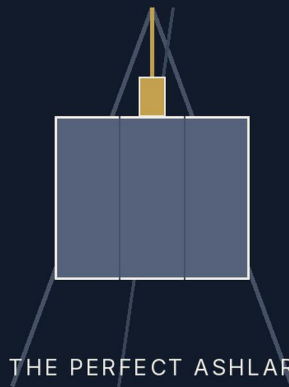
The lodge's own rough and perfect ashlar, on the table

ROUGH AND SMOOTH

One stone waiting. One stone under tension, held by iron, on its way into a wall it will not leave.



THE ROUGH ASHLAR
as it came from the quarry



THE PERFECT ASHLAR
squared, tried, and being lifted into place

The work was subtraction. Everything removed is gone, and the point of it is not the stone — a perfect ashlar on its own is useless. It is only anything at all when it is in a course.

Diagram drawn for *The Vulcan Papers*.

HOW THE PAPER RUNS

0:00	Opening
1:30	Start with the trade
3:00	What the working actually involved
5:00	Why one of them hangs
7:00	The part we usually get wrong
9:00	Closing

THREE THINGS TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 Ashlar is a builder's word, not a masonic one: squared, dressed stone laid in courses.
- 2 The perfect ashlar hangs from a lewis because it is shown in the act of being lifted into the wall.
- 3 The work was subtraction. Everything removed is gone, and the point of it is not the stone.

IF YOU ARE ASKED

Are the ashlar's movable or immovable jewels?

In the English working they are immovable jewels, with the tracing board. Other constitutions class them differently — a common source of confusion when visiting.

Why is the perfect ashlar suspended?

It hangs from a lewis, showing the dressed stone at the moment of being lifted into the building.

ROUGH AND SMOOTH



Does the rough ashlar mean a bad man?

No. It means an unworked one. The stone itself is sound; nothing has been done to it yet.

What is "trying and proving"?

Testing the worked faces with square and straightedge before the stone is accepted.

SOURCES

- Emulation Ritual — the explanation of the First Degree tracing board
- Harry Carr, The Freemason at Work, on the jewels and their classification
- Knoop & Jones, The Mediaeval Mason — operative practice, ashlar and rubble
- Any stone-built street in Middlesbrough, for the difference between a front elevation and a side wall

Every paper is drawn from openly published masonic literature. Nothing here discloses the esoteric work of any degree; all of it is safe to deliver with visitors present, provided the visitors are brethren.

The Vulcan Papers · Vulcan Lodge No. 4510 · Roman Road, Linthorpe, Middlesbrough